

SHORT FICTION · SCIENCE FICTION

The Reveal

A fragment

The Reveal

A fragment

Lawrence has a special power that lets him swap places with a version of himself from a parallel world. Even so, he cannot stay in that world more than a few minutes before he is pulled back, by force, into his own.

That day he had already passed through four worlds. One with dirty snow, where his other self was a postman. One where a food market stood where his apartment block should have been. Two so alike his own that he could not find the difference. That was all he ever got each time: a few minutes, and then his world dragged him back, always right on time. He held the air in his chest when he left, and he could stay a little, a breath longer than a breath. He liked to explore.

Now he was back in his room. It was clean, as always, the door locked. On the corner of the desk, untouched since yesterday, the apple his mother had brought. He did not want it. He had left it there to avoid the conversation.

He lay back down on the bed. The fifth world had been a disappointment: empty, dry, ugly, a parched plain under a sky

like an unwashed sheet of tin. He got bored fast and let himself be pulled home.

He opened his eyes and his gaze fell by accident on the clock. Ten past seven. He had left at six fifty.

Twenty minutes. For a few minutes on an empty plain.

He sat up. The door, locked. The window, shut. Everything in its place. Almost: the wastebasket, which he had emptied himself that morning, was no longer empty. At the bottom of it, an apple core, gnawed down to the seeds, still wet.

The corner of the desk was bare.

The thought came whole and very calm, the way the thoughts that change everything come: he had never once asked what his body did while he was away. He had been certain, without any proof, that it stayed there like a coat over a chair.

The second thought was madness. He listened to it. Later, in the abandoned factory where he had tested his power so many times, because no one ever came there, Lawrence put his plan into motion.

He turned on the camera. The red light blinked and stayed lit. On the old inventory board, with a stub of chalk, he wrote two

words. He looked at them the way a man looks when he hopes what he is doing is foolish.

He wrapped the chain across his chest and over his arms, passed it twice around the concrete pillar, closed the padlock and threw the key ten paces away, next to the tripod.

On his phone he wrote: "Come to the factory. Do not ask. Do not believe anything I say until you hear the password." He sent it, then flung the phone next to the key.

He sat down on the floor, his back to the pillar, the cold chain through his shirt. He drew in a breath and held it, and in the second before leaving he thought that this was the first time he was going to another world to learn something about his own.

A frozen harbor. Back. A stranger's living room, a woman screaming. Back. A fence, rain. Back. He did this without end. The air burned in his chest when he found it: the cracked plain, the sky like tin. He returned at once. But he felt a lurch in his ears and pain through his whole body.

He woke with his body tipped forward and the taste of rust in his mouth. His wrists stung: the skin scraped raw to blood. The chain sat differently than he had bound it, tighter, and it looked well wrenched.

Soon after, Hack's footsteps sounded through the hall.

Lawrence spoke the password before his friend could ask anything.

"How long since I wrote to you?" Lawrence asked at once, not wasting time on the worried looks.

"What? Ah, I think... twenty minutes?" Hack crouched down beside him. He was not looking at the chain. He was looking at the wrists. "Do you want me to untie you?"

"...For me, a few seconds."

They found the key where he had thrown it. They played the recording back together.

On the small screen, twenty minutes earlier, Lawrence saw his body slump limp into the chain, chin to chest. Asleep. A few seconds. Still.

Then the body lifted its head.

Not like a man waking. Like a man searching. Confused at first, it looked toward the chains. The chest began to rise and fall, fast, faster, and that hoarse, foreign breathing filled the whole hall through the camera's speaker. The head turned toward the board. It stayed like that for one long second. The eyes moved straight to the camera.

Then his body wrenched against the chain like an animal, once, and again, wrists twisting in the links, until the head dropped inert.

Hack stopped the recording. He said nothing.

Lawrence set the camera down and lifted his eyes to the board, to the two words written in chalk by his own hand, for someone who was not him.

[I caught you]

Hack drew a breath.

“I have a theory, maybe there are other versions of you who know about this pow...”

“Not now, Hack,” Lawrence sighed.

Lawrence arrived back in his room and looked around it. Everything was clean, in its place.

Stefan Petrovici